

2000 ▶ 1000 BCE



Clay tablet with an earlier working of Pythagoras's theorem, c 2000 BCE



Proto-Sinaitic letter M



Proto-Sinaitic letter H

1800 BCE

Babylonian math

Scholars in the city of Babylon (in Mesopotamia, now modern Iraq) worked out a complex mathematical system, which they wrote in cuneiform script (see p.13) on clay tablets. The tablet seen here displays a version of Pythagoras's theorem. The text shows the square root of two, correct to six decimal places.

1800 BCE

Earliest alphabetic script

Turquoise miners in Egypt's Sinai Desert developed the world's earliest alphabetic script. Now known as Proto-Sinaitic, it was based on a version of Egyptian hieroglyphs (see p.13), but with each symbol representing a single sound. Proto-Sinaitic consisted of consonants only.

Archer fires from platform



▶▶ 2000

1800

1600

1800 BCE

The composite bow

Probably invented in Central Asia, the composite bow was made by bonding layers of horn, wood, and strips of animal sinew. It was not only stronger than bows made with just one material, it also allowed archers to shoot arrows further and with greater force.

1650 BCE

Studying Venus

The Venus cuneiform tablets, compiled in the reign of the Babylonian King Ammisaduqa, are the earliest detailed records of astronomical observations. The text on the clay tablets gives the times of the rising and setting of the planet Venus over a period of 21 years.



1560 BCE

The Ebers papyrus

One of the oldest medical texts, this papyrus from Egypt contains recipes for medicines and describes ailments such as tumors, depression, and tinnitus (ringing in the ears). It shows early understanding of the heart's role in the body's blood supply.



Fish-shaped glass bottle for ointments, c 1370 BCE

Glass production

Around 1500 BCE, Egyptian glassmakers discovered how to use metal rods to dip a core of silica paste into molten glass. When the glass solidified, the core was cut away, creating the earliest glass vessels.